

Saint John Chrysostom
Homilies on David and Saul

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HOMILY I.

On David and Saul, and on tolerance, and that one ought to spare enemies, nor speak ill of those who are absent.

1. Whenever some prolonged and harsh inflation has clung to bodies, then both a long time, much labor, and much wisdom are needed in applying remedies, so that the collected swelling may be dissolved without danger to life. The same can be seen in the soul. For whenever someone has a disease that has taken root in the soul, if it has been long-concreted, it is not enough for the correction to have one or two days of admonition: rather, it is necessary to frequently treat this matter over several days; provided that we do this not for ambition and pleasure, but for the fruit and utility of the office we are to perform as preachers. Therefore, just as we have done regarding oaths, discussing the same subject with you over many days, so let us now do the same regarding anger, pursuing a continuous exhortation about it for our part indeed. For it seems to me that this is the best method of teaching, if we do not cease advising on any matter until we see the admonition has reached its effect. Indeed, he who today speaks of almsgiving, tomorrow of prayer, then of humanity, and again of the modesty of the soul, will not be able to accomplish any of these things rightly in the minds of the listeners, always leaping from this to that, and again from that to another: but it is necessary that whoever wishes to achieve the intended fruit of prayer in the minds of the listeners does not cease advising and consulting on the same matters, nor leap to anything else until he has seen the previous admonition well fixed and rooted in them. The same is done by schoolmasters: they do not lead children to syllables until they have seen the knowledge of the elements rightly confirmed in them. Recently, therefore, we have explained to you the parable of the hundred denarii and the ten thousand talents, showing how great an evil it is to remember injuries. For whom the ten thousand

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talents did not lose, the hundred denarii have condemned, and they have revoked the forgiveness granted for debts, and they have squandered the remission of the owed money (Matt. 18), and they have dragged him, who had been freed from crimes, back to judgment, and from there they have thrown him into prison, finally delivering him to immortal punishment. But today we will attempt to speak on a different subject. For it was necessary, if what was just were to be done, for one speaking of humanity and gentleness to provide examples from that philosopher's teaching, and thus to teach it both with words and to establish it with deeds. But since we are far removed from this virtue by a long interval, having produced one of the saints in the midst, and placed before your eyes, we will apply a certain clear and powerful exhortation, so that we may encourage both you and ourselves as if to the emulation of some archetype.

Who then is to be brought forth as a mediator in speaking of humanity? Who indeed but he who has deserved to be praised by heavenly testimony, for this very reason most to be regarded with suspicion? I have found, he says, David the son of Jesse, a man after my own heart (1. Reg. 13. 14; Act. 13. 22). Moreover, after God has pronounced, there remains no opportunity for contradiction. For his judgment is incorrupt, since God judges neither out of grace nor out of hatred, but grants a vote purely for the virtue of the soul. Yet we have not produced this mediator solely because he was praised by God's vote, but also because he is one of those who were educated under the old laws. Indeed, under the law of grace, it is not surprising that someone has existed who is pure from wrath, forgiving the offenses of enemies, and sparing those who have been affected with annoyance, especially after the death of Christ, after he so graciously remitted all our sins, after so many precepts filled with the philosophy of the Gospel: however, in the Old Testament, when the law permitted an eye for an

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eye to be shed, and a tooth for a tooth to be extracted (Exod. 21. 24), and to avenge him who had been injured with the penalty of retaliation, has anyone existed who has transcended the limits of the precepts and reached the apostolic philosophy, who would not bring the listeners to astonishment? Who, if we do not imitate him, would not deprive us of all pardon and all excuse? But in order that you may more accurately know his virtue, allow me to repeat the prayer a little higher, and to recall the benefits which that blessed man conferred upon Saul. For it is not surprising not to avenge an enemy who has simply harmed, but he who has benefited a man affected by many benefits, yet who has attempted to kill him once and again, indeed frequently, after having fallen into his hands, when it was now permitted to kill, not only did he not let him go, but also rescued him from the snares of others; especially since he knew that he would plot the same afterward: what did he leave remaining that could be added to the highest philosophy?

2. But let me briefly recount the benefits that David conferred upon Saul, when and how. Once, when the Jews were pressed by a most difficult war, so much so that all were struck with fear and no one dared to raise their head, but the city was in extreme desperation, with each person having death before their eyes and all expecting destruction daily, living a life more miserable than those who dwell in the most dreadful prison, David, coming from the sheep to the army, although he was not skilled in the art of warfare due to his youth and was untrained in military labors, took upon himself the battle for all and managed the affair successfully, beyond what anyone would have hoped. Although even if the outcome had failed him, he would still have been crowned for the mere readiness of spirit and the noble intention. Now, if someone of the soldiers, in the vigor of age, had planned this deed, it would have been nothing surprising, evidently as required by military law. But here was one who saw no necessity

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compelling him to this, and he even had many dissuading him: for his brother rebuked him, and the king, seeing that he was not yet of mature age and unfit to endure dangers, restrained him and ordered him to stay, saying: "You cannot go, for you are a boy: but he is a man, a warrior from his youth" (1. Reg. 17.33). Yet, although no occasion provoked him, he, of his own accord and inflamed by divine zeal and love for his country, ran so boldly against the barbarians as if he were seeing sheep rather than men, and as if he were about to attack dogs rather than such a numerous army of men. And at that time, he showed such concern for the king that he even raised him up, prostrated before him, before the battle and victory. For he not only helped him by deeds, but also encouraged him with words to be of good courage and persuaded him to conceive good hope regarding the outcome, speaking thus: "Let not my lord's heart fail him, for your servant will go and fight with this foreigner" (Ibid. v. 52). I ask, does it seem small that, without any necessity compelling him, he should risk his own life and rush into the midst of enemies from whom he had received no benefit? Was it not fitting to honor him after such a deed with the title of lord inscribed on columns and to call him the public savior of the city, who preserved both the glory of the kingdom and the foundations of the cities, and the life of all by the grace of God? What greater benefit could this be? For it conferred not glory or power, but life itself, and it rescued him from the very gates of death: thus, if you consider human assistance, by that benefit he scarcely saved the king and preserved the principality. And afterwards, what gratitude did he repay him? For if someone weighs the greatness of the deeds accomplished, even if the king had placed the crown taken from his own head upon David's head, he would never have returned equal gratitude, but should have owed a greater one. For he indeed gave him both life and kingdom, but the latter was only to yield the kingdom to him. However, let us consider the gratitude given for the good deeds. What was that, then? From that

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day forth, David was suspected by him and feared for himself. Why and for what reason? For the cause of suspicion must be mentioned. For whatever someone may say, he will affirm that it is just. For against one who endangered his life and gave it, what could be a just cause for suspicion? But let us examine the very cause of enmity, that you may learn something, which is not inferior to victory itself: that David, being worthy of honor for those very things, was afterwards brought into suspicion and was assailed by treachery. What, then, was the cause of suspicion? After the barbarian took off his head and returned bearing the spoils: "The women came out singing and saying: 'Saul has struck down his thousands, and David his ten thousands.'" And Saul was angry and suspected David from that day forth and afterwards (1. Reg. 18.6-9). For what reason, I ask? Even if these words had been said without merit, it was not right to bear a hostile spirit against David: but after he had learned of his goodwill towards him from the deeds done, since he had willingly submitted to danger without any compulsion, he ought not to have suspected anything evil from him thereafter. Now, however, praises were being proclaimed; and if it is right to speak the truth, those words were rather said in favor of Saul than in favor of David; he ought to have been satisfied that they had attributed a thousand to him. Why, then, was he angry that they attributed ten thousands to David? For if the king had contributed even a little to the end of the war, it would have been rightly said, "Saul in thousands, David in ten thousands." But if he indeed sat at home, fearful and trembling, expecting death each day, while this one accomplished the whole deed: was it not absurd for him to be indignant at one who contributed nothing to avert danger, simply because he received less praise? For if indignation was warranted, it would have been more fitting for Saul to be indignant at David, since he alone had accomplished the whole thing, while the other had a share in the praise.

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3. But I say nothing of these things: rather I would say this: that we should grant that women did not act rightly, and that they were subject to me, and worthy of accusation, what does this have to do with David? For he himself did not compose the song, nor did he persuade them to say what they were saying, nor did he adorn that mode of praise. Therefore, even if it was to be indignation, it was the women who ought to have been indignant, not about the well-deserving city, and the countless worthy of crowns. But Saul, disregarding those things, was angry with David. Now if that blessed one, raised by such praise, had envied the overflowing, and had been contemptuous of him, and had scorned his authority, perhaps there would have been some cause for envy: but if he became more humane and modest, if he restrained himself in the order of his subordinates, what then was a just cause for sorrow? For when one who is honored is raised up against him from whom he has been advanced, and does not cease to abuse that honor with contempt, he has some excuse for sorrow: however, when he persists in honoring him, or rather obeys more, and yields in all things, what pretext for envy can he later have? David is not carried away by prosperous success.

Therefore, even if nothing else had been accomplished excellently, for this very reason he was more worthy of love, because when he had obtained such a great opportunity to seize the kingdom, he remained steadfast in his modesty. For neither the things that had been done before, nor those that followed, which were much more excellent than the previous ones, raised his spirits. What then were those things? He was, it is said, prudent in all his ways, and the Almighty Lord was with him, and all Israel and Judah loved David, because he went in and out before the sight of the people. And Michal, the daughter of Saul, and all Israel loved him. And he was wiser than all the servants of Saul; and his name was greatly honored (1 Sam. 18:14, 16, 20, 30). And

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Jonathan, the son of Saul, loved David very much (1 Sam. 18:2). Nevertheless, although he had the entire people and the royal family won over to him, and he was victorious everywhere in battles, and never failed in success, and received such grace for those well-done things, he did not raise his neck, nor did he aspire to the kingdom, nor did he take vengeance on the enemy, but persevered in doing good, and in successfully conducting wars for the king. Who is so hardened and cruel that these things would not persuade him to lay aside enmity and cast off envy? But that cruel and inhuman man was not moved by any of these things; but blind to all this, and devoted to envy, he attempted to remove him from the midst: and what, I ask, was he doing? (for this is greater and more astonishing,) while playing the harp, and soothing his madness. David, it is said, played with his own hand daily: and Saul had a spear in his hand: and Saul lifted the spear, and said, I will pin David to the wall; and he aimed to strike David to the wall twice (Ibid. v. 11). Can anything be added to this malice? Perhaps those things that followed afterward. He who had recently driven away the enemies, through whom the city had been restored to him, while all were sacrificing victims for victory: Saul attempted to kill the singing one, the benefactor and savior, and the author of those good things; and he did not even restrain him, though he was raging and delirious, by the memory of benefits, but once and again he was twisting him with these things, and with these even greater ones.

5. But the just man did not weigh any of these things in his mind, looking only at how he could redeem the crown of patience and exercise a certain admirable philosophy. For it was not surprising, if, being alone and without companions, he had spared the one by whom he had been injured, and now does the same to others present: for the presence of those soldiers was a double obstacle to philosophy. It frequently happens to us that when we have stood ready to remit

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vengeance and forgive offenses; afterwards, when we see some provoking and inciting us, we change our mind and obey their words. But this did not happen to this blessed man, for even after their counsel and exhortation, he persevered in his purpose of mind. Yet this is not even the only thing worthy of admiration, that he was not moved from his purpose by the admonition of others, nor was he afraid of them, but that he accomplished it, so that they too would take on the same moderation of mind. Indeed, it is great if someone can command his own desires: but it is much greater to be able to persuade others, so that they too may have the same mind: I say others, who are not modest men, nor temperate, but soldiers, who had already been brought to desperation by many difficulties, from whom they wished to breathe a little, not unaware that not only the entire solution of evils lay in the death of the enemy; nor only the solution of evils, but also the acquisition of many goods, since nothing stood in the way of the kingdom passing immediately to David with that one slain. Nevertheless, although there were so many things that provoked the soldiers, that noble man was so strong that he was superior to all these things, and he persuaded them to spare the enemy.

It is truly worth the effort to hear the counsel of the soldiers themselves, for the shrewdness of counsel reveals a firm and solid spirit of justice. For they did not speak thus: Behold, he who has devised many evils against you, who has coveted your death, who has surrounded us with insurmountable difficulties: but when they perceived that David neglected all these things, and did not have a great regard for the things committed, they allege to him the divine author, saying, God delivered him to you, so that, revering the judgment from God, he might more readily go to murder. Do you not, they ask, avenge your own case? You serve and minister to God, you approve of His sentence. But the more they said these things, the more

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he spared the enemy, for he understood that God had delivered him in order to provide him with greater opportunities to prove his virtue. Therefore, you too, if ever the enemy should fall into your hands, beware of thinking that vengeance is given, but rather the opportunity to preserve the enemy. And thus, it is especially to be spared from enemies when they have perhaps come into our power. But perhaps someone might say here: And what great thing, or what wonder, do you have in your power to spare? For many and great kings, having been raised to the pinnacle of power, deemed themselves unworthy in such a height of the kingdom to exact penalties from those by whom they had once been offended: the very elevation of power brought forth the cause of reconciliation. But in this case, you cannot say such a thing. For neither was David raised to power, nor did he obtain the kingdom, and having the sword in his hands, he spared him, so that no one could claim that the wrath had been removed because of the greatness of the kingdom: but knowing that he would be preserved, he would return again to the same, and he himself would be thrown into graver dangers, he did not kill him for that reason either. Nor should we compare this with them. For they, since they have a certain and secure pledge of future safety, rightly spare; but here, knowing that he was letting the enemy go to his own destruction and granting safety to the foe, he did not kill him, although he had many things urging him to that murder. Indeed, the solitude of the king, stripped of help, the exhortation of the soldiers, the memory of past events, the fear of future ones; to this it is added that if he had killed the enemy, he could not be condemned for the deed, and that after the deed was done, he would seem to overcome the law itself by his gentleness, these and many other things urged and compelled him to pierce him with the sword. But none of these things yielded to him, but like an unconquered diamond, he persisted, keeping the unblemished law of philosophy. Moreover, do not say that he felt none of those emotions,

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which he ought to have felt, but that what happened was not philosophy, but stupor: consider how vehemently he restrained himself. For indeed, the waves of anger swelled in his mind, and a great storm of thoughts was stirred up, but he restrained that tempest through the fear of God, and repressed his spirits, as can be seen from what was done. He arose, he said, and secretly took the hem of Saul's cloak. Do you see how great a storm of anger had arisen? But he did not proceed further, nor did he commit any act of violence, because the helmsman, immediately sensing the danger, namely, pious reason, turned the tempest into tranquility. For he struck, he said, David's heart, and like a leaping and fierce horse, he recalled his anger.

6. Such are the souls of the saints: before they fall, they rise again; before they reach sin, they are restrained, because they are sober, and they are always vigilant. And yet, how great was the interval between the body and the garment? Nevertheless, he restrained himself, lest he should proceed further: moreover, for this very reason, he severely condemned himself. For he struck, he says, his own heart, because he had taken away the extreme hem of the cloak, and he said to the men: "Let this never be to me from the Lord" (1. Reg. 24. 6). What is that, "Let this never be to me from the Lord"? He says, "May the Lord be gracious to me, if I had wished this: may God never allow me to do this, nor permit me to come to such a state." For he saw that this philosophy nearly surpasses human nature, and requires heavenly assistance, and that he had nearly proceeded to murder; he prays that the Lord may keep his hand unpolluted. What could be milder than this in spirit? Shall we say of this man that he has lived an angelic life in human nature? But divine laws will not allow this. For who, I ask, would easily ask God for such a thing? What did I say, such a thing? Who would endure not to pray against him who had been troublesome? For many mortals have been so seized by ferocity that, although they

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are so weak that they cannot harm him from whom they have been provoked, they invoke God for vengeance, that He may grant them the ability to harm those who have done them wrong. But he, on the contrary, praying as if from the diametrical opposite, asks that he may not be permitted to lay a hand on him, speaking in this manner: "Let this not happen to me from the Lord, that I should lay my hand upon him" (1. Reg. 24.6): just as he speaks of a son and offspring, so he speaks of an enemy.

He not only spared him, but also prepared an excuse for him. See how wisely and how prudently. For indeed, when examining the life of Saul, he found nothing good to say, that he might declare, "He has not harmed me, nor has he been affected by any inconvenience" (for immediately the soldiers who were present would have protested, having known the malice of the king by experience): on the other hand, he went around, seeking to find a plausible excuse. When he could not do this, nor from his life, nor from his deeds, he resorted to his dignity, saying: "For he is the Christ of the Lord." What do you say, they ask? What a wicked man, covered with crimes, and filled with countless vices, thinking the worst of us? But he is a king, but a prince, but he has assumed the principality over us. Yet he did not say, "He is a king," but "He is the Christ of the Lord," not taken from human honor, but from a heavenly judgment drawn from a honorable testimony. "Do you despise," he says, "your servant? Honor the Lord. Do you scorn the chosen one? Fear him who chose." For if we fear and tremble before those common prefects designated by the Emperor, even if they are wicked, if they are thieves, if they are robbers, if they are unjust, or whatever else they may be, we do not despise them because of their malice, but we revere the dignity of him from whom they were chosen: much more fitting is it to do this towards those whom God has chosen. "God has not yet," he says, "abdicated him from the principality, nor

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has he made him a private man from a king." Therefore, let us not invert the order, nor fight against God, presenting that apostolic saying in deeds: "For whoever resists the authority resists the ordinance of God; and those who resist will receive condemnation upon themselves" (Rom. 13. 2). He not only called him Christ, that is, anointed and king; but he also called him his lord. It is no small philosophy to call an enemy by the names of honor and obedience. And again, how great this is, one can perceive from those things that happen to others. Indeed, many do not even endure to call their enemies by bare and simple names, but they name them with other hateful words: impious, insane, possessed, delirious, pestilent: they weave many other things, and designate the enemy with these marks. That this is true, I will teach by an example not far off, but taken from close by, namely from this very Saul, who could not bear to call this just man by his proper name out of vehement hatred, but when a certain feast was being celebrated, he inquired, saying, "Where is the son of Jesse?" (1 Reg. 20. 27) Thus he called him partly out of hatred for his proper name, partly noting the vileness of his father, hoping that in this way the reputation of the just would be contaminated: not understanding that a noble and illustrious man is made such, not by the brightness of his ancestors, but by the virtue of his soul. But blessed David did not do likewise. For he did not call him by his father's surname, although he too was very humble and despised: nor did he designate him by a bare and simple name, but by the title of dignity and principality. So pure was his mind from all malevolence. Therefore you too, dearest, imitating him, learn this above all, never to call an enemy by hateful names, but rather by honorable ones. For if the mouth becomes accustomed to calling him who has harmed by names of honor and obedience, the mind, hearing this from the learned tongue, will not refuse to return to favor with him. For the very words will be the best remedy for the swelling wound in the heart.

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7. I have now spoken these things, not only to praise David, but also to emulate him. Therefore, let each one of us depict this history in his own heart, as if with a hand, continually delineating in the mind that double cave, Saul himself sleeping within, bound by sleep just as by a chain, subject to the right hand of him whom he had grievously wounded; David looming over the sleeping man, the present soldiers, and urging them to kill; that blessed man philosophizing, that is, restraining his own anger against him who had sinned so much, and excusing him. These things, I say, let us not only depict in our minds, but also let us continually speak of them in our gatherings: let us frequently renew these narratives with our wives, with our children. For whether you wish to speak of the king, behold the king: whether of soldiers, or of household matters, or of public and civil affairs, you will find in the Scriptures a great abundance of all these. Such recollections bring great benefit. For it is impossible, I say, it is impossible for a mind engaged in such histories to be overcome by desires. Therefore, let us not waste time uselessly, nor let us spend our lives in vain on foolish and superfluous trifles, but let us learn the deeds of brave men, and let us discuss these things continually. And if anyone in the assembly wishes to speak either about spectacles, or about horse racing, or about matters that do not concern you, let him be recalled from that subject, and let him be led into such a narrative, so that, while our minds are purified, and delighted with a pleasure that is free from danger, we ourselves may become gentle and placable towards all who have wronged us, and departing from this life, may attain eternal goods in the future age, having no enemy, through the grace and goodness of our Lord Jesus Christ, to whom be glory forever. Amen.

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That it is a great good not only to practice virtue, but also to praise: and that David erected a magnificent trophy by sparing Saul, rather than by prostrating Goliath: and that in doing this he benefited himself more than Saul: and concerning his excuse before Saul.

1. It is beneficial to praise those endowed with virtue. --Indeed, you recently praised David for his endurance of evils; I, in turn, admired your goodwill towards David and your affection of charity. For it is not enough to merely approach and emulate virtue, but also to elevate those who embrace virtue with praises and to proclaim them as admirable, which brings us some fruit, and not a common one: just as, on the contrary, merely not to emulate wickedness, but also to praise those living in it, prepares for us no small punishment; and if it is permissible to say something new and admirable, a graver punishment awaits those who praise evil than those who live wickedly themselves. This is declared by Paul, after he had enumerated every kind of malice and accused all who trample on the laws of God, he adds concerning them: Who knowing the judgment of God, that they which commit such things are worthy of death, not only do the same, but have pleasure in them that do them: therefore you are inexcusable, O man (Rom. 1. 32 and c. 2. v. 1). You see him speaking in such a way as to show that this is graver than that. For to praise the wicked, as it pertains to punishment, is far more than to commit wickedness: and this justly, because such a vote arises from a mind thoroughly corrupt and suffering from an incurable disease. For indeed, he who while sinning condemns his sin, may at some point in the progress of time return to himself; but he who praises wickedness has deprived himself of the cure that repentance brings. Therefore, Paul rightly declared this to be graver. Thus, just as not only those who do evil, but also those who praise and proclaim such, incur the same or even a graver

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punishment: so those who carry and proclaim the praises of the good become partakers of the crowns laid up for them. This very thing can be seen in Scripture. For God speaks to Abraham in this way: I will bless those who bless you, and I will curse those who curse you (Gen. 12. 3). The same can be seen in the Olympic contests by anyone. For neither does the athlete alone wear the crown, nor does he who has endured labor and sweat alone, but also he who praises the victor reaps no small pleasure from that praise. Therefore, I do not only proclaim that noble and magnanimous man blessed for his philosophical spirit, but also you for your benevolent spirit towards him. He contended and won, and took the crown; but you, because you praised the victory, have not taken a small part of the crown for yourselves. So that this pleasure may be more abundant for you, and the fruit more plentiful, let us now also pay off the remaining parts of this history to you. When the historian had mentioned the words by which David condemned the slaughter, he added: He did not permit them to rise up and kill Saul (1. Reg. 24.8): at the same time demonstrating their minds ready for the same, and wishing to show this fortitude. But many who seem to philosophize, even if they themselves do not receive murder, nevertheless do not restrain others who prepare for slaughter. And not David, but just as if he had received some deposit, for which he would have to give an account, he not only did not touch the enemy, but also restrained others wishing to kill, becoming the best of guards and a protector of the body. Therefore, it is not far from the truth to say that David fell into a more serious crisis at that time than Saul himself. For he was not enduring a light contest and danger, while he was trying in every way to rescue him from the ambushes that the soldiers were preparing for him: nor did he fear so much that he himself would be killed, as he feared that someone, obeying the wrath of the soldiers, would kill the man: and for this reason he devised such an excuse. And indeed they were accusing, but Saul was being accused while sleeping,

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but the enemy was defended, and God was the judge, and confirmed David's sentence. For they would not have been able to conquer the raging ones without God's protection: but it was by God's grace residing in the lips of the prophet, which added a certain authority to his words. Although David did not bring a light moment here, for since he had instructed them in former times, therefore at the moment of the contest he found them ready and obedient. For he had not been in charge of them as a military leader, but as a priest, and already that was the church.

Thus, just as someone who has received the office of bishop was giving a sermon to them, and after the sermon offered the sacrifice, it is something remarkable and incredible to say, not with a sacrificed calf or a slain lamb, but with something much more honorable than these, offering gentleness and humanity to God, and with an irrational movement of the mind having been sacrificed, and with anger slain, and the members mortified, which are upon the earth. And he became at the same time both the victim and the one sacrificed, and the altar (Col. 3. 5). For indeed, both the reason that offered gentleness and humanity, and the very humanity and gentleness, finally the heart in which these were offered, all belonged to the same man.

2. Therefore, after he had sacrificed this splendid victim, he then reported the victory and left nothing out that pertained to the trophy; finally, the subject of these contests arose, Saul, and he came out of the cave, unaware of all that had happened. David also came out after him (1. Reg. 24.9), looking up to heaven with liberated eyes, and at that time rejoicing more than when he had struck down Goliath and cut off the head of the barbarian. Indeed, this was a more magnificent victory, these spoils were more magnificent, this prey was more illustrious, this trophy was more glorious. For there, he had to work with a sling and stones and in battle; here, however, everything was accomplished with

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wisdom and reason, and victory was achieved without arms, and a bloodless trophy was erected. Therefore, he returned not bearing the head of that barbarian, but a calmness of spirit, a subdued anger; nor did he place these spoils in Jerusalem, but in heaven, in the heavenly city. Now, women did not come out dancing to meet him with praises, but the host of angels applauded from on high, admiring his philosophy and humanity. For he ascended, wounded by countless injuries from the enemy, so that although he had spared Saul, he nonetheless had pierced that enemy, the devil, with many blows. For just as when we are fighting among ourselves in anger, and colliding with mutual conflict, he then rejoices and is glad; so when we have peace and concord, moderating our anger, he is again contracted and cast down, namely, the enemy of peace and the foe of concord, and the father of envy. Therefore, David came out, bearing that right hand equal in price to the whole world, crowned at the same time with the head. For just as often emperors crown the right hand of those who have distinguished themselves in the contest of fighters, either of a boxer or a pankratiast: so God crowned that hand, which could lead a pure sword, and show a sword to God untainted by any blood, finally to resist against such a storm of anger. He did not come out bearing Saul's diadem, but he came out bearing the crown of justice; he did not come out wearing the purple robe of a king, but he came out clothed in humanity, surpassing human nature, which is a garment more magnificent than any robe.

He came out of the cave, with such glory, as the three youths came out of the burning furnace. For just as the fire did not burn them, so here the fire of wrath did not blaze. And indeed, nothing harmful affected them outside (Dan. 3): but here, although he had burning coals within, and saw the devil outside kindling the furnace, from the sight of the enemy, from the exhortation of the soldiers, from the ease of completing the temple, from the solitude of those who could assist

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Saul, from the memory of past dangers and the fear of future ones (for these indeed stirred up a brighter flame with brushwood, pitch, stubble, and all the other things with which that Babylonian furnace was kindled), yet David did not blaze up, nor was he affected in such a way that it was fitting for him to become so: but he came out pure, and from the sight of the enemy's face, he drew forth a strong and philosophical spirit. For when he saw him sleeping and remaining motionless, and unable to do anything, he spoke to his own mind: where now is that fury? where is that malice? where are so many tricks, so many snares? All those things have gone away, and perished through the slight incursion of sleep: the king lies bound, while we have neither thought of these things, nor accomplished them. He saw him sleeping, and philosophized about death common to all. For sleep is nothing other than a temporary and daily destruction. It is not untimely for someone to remember Daniel here. For just as he ascended from the pit after overcoming the fierce lions (Dan. 14), so here he came forth from the cave, having defeated beasts far more savage. For just as those righteous lions were sitting here and there, so here he was invaded by all the more ferocious and stronger movements of the mind: on one side indignation about the past, on the other side fear of the future: but he restrained both of these here, closing the mouths of the beasts, teaching by his very deeds that there is nothing safer than to spare the enemy, against nothing more dangerous than to wish to take vengeance and to seek retribution. Therefore, the other who had determined to attack, naked and unarmed, and deprived of all assistance, lay no differently than a captive handed over into the hands of the enemy: but here, while he yields, and gives way everywhere, and does not even wish to lay hands unjustly, without machines, without arms, without cavalry, without soldiers, he took the enemy into his power; and what is the greatest of all, he made God more benevolent towards himself.

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3. How much David gained by sparing Saul. It is much greater to spare than to destroy. - For I do not proclaim that holy man blessed because he saw the enemy lying under his feet, but because he spared him when given into his hands. One of these was the work of divine power, the other of his philosophy. How fitting was it for the soldiers to observe him afterwards, how much goodwill they must have felt towards him? For if they had a thousand lives, would they not have willingly laid them down for their leader, already perceiving from the reverence he showed to the enemy, how benevolent his spirit was towards his own? For he who was gentle and meek towards those who troubled him, would be much more so towards those who were well-disposed: which indeed was for him the greatest pledge of security. But they were not only more benevolent towards him, but also more eager against the enemies: because they knew they had God as their protector, who was always present to the leader, overseeing all his actions. Therefore, afterwards they obeyed David, not now as a man, but as an angel. And thus David, even before God repaid him with a reward, received a greater prize in this life, and achieved a more illustrious victory by sparing Saul than if he had slain him. For what would he have gained by killing the enemy, compared to what he gained by sparing him? Therefore, weigh this and consider with yourself, where you have seen him quite harmed, that it is much greater and more profitable to spare than to destroy. For indeed, he who kills an enemy often condemns himself, bearing a corrupt conscience, while he is afflicted daily and hourly by that pressing sin: but he who spares, and in a short time conquers his passions, afterwards rejoices and delights, supported by the best hope, and expecting the rewards of patience from God. And if at any time he falls into some evil, he will confidently demand a reward from God: as indeed he received great and wonderful rewards from God for the mercy shown to the enemy. But let us see what follows. David came out of the cave after Saul, and called after him,

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saying: My lord the king. And Saul looked behind him, and David bowed his face to the ground and worshipped him (1. Sam. 24. 9). These things contribute no less to David's adornment than the spared enemy. For he was not of a common spirit, not puffed up by the benefits conferred on him by his neighbor, nor affected as most of the common people are, who, just as they look down on those whom they have helped with disdainful brows (a). But blessed David was not so, but rather appeared more modest after the bestowed benefits. The reason was that he attributed nothing of those things which had been splendidly done to his own efforts, but ascribed everything to the divine gift. Therefore, he who had spared, also worshipped the spared one, and again called him king, and called himself a servant, repressing the swelling of his spirit due to that dignity, calming his anger, and removing envy. Let us further hear the very exclamation itself. Why do you listen to the words of the people, saying, Behold, David seeks your life (1. Sam. 24. 10)? And yet the one who wrote this history previously said that all the people were with David, and that he was gracious in the eyes of the king's servants, and that the son of the prince and the whole army stood with David (2. Sam. 18. 16, 22, 28, and c. 19. 1). How then does he say that there were those who falsely accused him, and provoked Saul against him? For since he had not conceived this malice by the instigation of others, but from his own mind, the one who wrote the volume declared this when he said that envy was born from the praises of David, and then grew day by day (1. Sam. 18. 9, 29). For what reason then did he transfer the crime to others, saying: Why do you listen to the words of your people, saying, Behold, David seeks your life? Surely to provide them with an opportunity to shake off their malice. This indeed is what parents often do towards their children, when someone, reproving his corrupt son, who has committed many evils, although he is convinced that he has driven him to corrupt morals by his own malice, often casts the blame

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onto others, saying: I know it was not your fault, but others have corrupted and seduced you: it is their entire sin. For hearing this, the son, gradually recovering from his malice, can more easily return to good behavior, while feeling ashamed and blushing to be seen as unworthy of such praise. Paul did the same when writing to the Galatians. After many long discourses, and after not mentioning the accusations by which he had accused them, at the end of the letter, wishing to remove their guilt, so that they might be somewhat refreshed from their crimes and come to an excuse, he speaks in this manner: I have confidence in you, that you will feel nothing else: but he who troubles you shall bear judgment, whoever he may be (Gal. 5. 10). David did the same here: for when he says, Why do you listen to the words of the people saying: Behold, David seeks your life? he indicates that there are others who provoke, others who infect his spirit, striving to provide him with an opportunity for excuse. Soon, addressing his own cause, he says: Behold, your eyes have seen today that the Lord delivered you into my hands in the cave, and that I would not kill you, but spared you, and said: I will not lay my hand upon my lord, for he is the anointed of the Lord (1. Sam. 24. 11). They indeed, he says, slander with words, but I truly cleanse myself, and by my deeds I dispel the crime. I have no need for words, since the outcome of events can teach you more clearly than any speech, who those are from whom I, and how the slander was made against me. For these things I call no other witness, but you yourself, I say, since you have been spared by my kindness.

4. But how could Saul be a witness of these things, who while these things were happening, was sleeping, and neither heard the words nor saw David present, speaking with the soldiers? How then shall we meet, so that an evident declaration may be made? For if he had summoned the witnesses, Saul would have suspected their testimony,

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and would have thought that they were speaking in favor of him unjustly. But if he had attempted to excuse himself with reasoning and probable arguments, it would have been such that he would have been less believed, since the mind of the judge was already corrupted. For how could he, who was affected by so many benefits, pursue with war one who had done him no wrong, suspecting that someone wronged would spare him who had done the injury? For often the common people judge others from their own mind: as, for example, one who is constantly drunk can hardly believe that anyone lives soberly; one who is given to debauchery considers even those living chastely to be incontinent; again, one who seizes the property of others will not easily be persuaded that there are people who also spend their own. Similarly, he who was once seized by anger would not easily have believed that there was a man so superior to his own passions, that he would not only do no harm, but also preserve him who was harmed. Therefore, since the mind of the judge was corrupted, and the witnesses, if produced, would have been under suspicion, he found a certain prudent counsel, which could also shut the mouth of the very impudent. What is this? The hem of the cloak, which he stretched out, saying: Behold, the hem of your cloak in my hand, which I have cut off, and I did not kill you (1. Sam. 24:12). A mute witness, but more evident than all those having a voice. For he said, "Indeed, if I had not been near you, I could not have cut off a part of your garment." Do you see how much good arose from that, which at first had moved David? For if he had not been moved to anger, we would not have known the philosophy of the man (for in many cases he would have seemed to have spared not from philosophy, but from astonishment), nor would he have cut off a part of the cloak: for if he had not cut it off, he could not have made the enemy believe with other arguments. But now, since he was both moved and cut off, he provided a most certain argument of his providence. Therefore, since he exhibited such a true and undoubted

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testimony, he soon makes the enemy himself both the judge and the witness of his reverence towards him, speaking in this manner: "Know and see today that there is no wickedness in my hand, nor contempt of you, and you bind my soul, that you may take it" (Ibid.). From this, one ought to marvel most at his magnanimity, that he does not take an excuse except from those things which had happened that day. For this he hints at when he says: "Know and see today." For I speak nothing of past events: for me, this day is sufficient for proof. Although he could have enumerated many great benefits, which he had previously conferred upon him, if he had wished: he could have recalled the singular contest which he had undertaken with the barbarian, and say: "When the barbaric war, like a certain flood, was about to destroy the whole city, with you terrified and trembling in fear, expecting death every day, I, coming forward without anyone compelling me, indeed you prohibiting and restraining me, saying: 'You cannot go, for you are a boy, but he is a man of war in his youth' (1. Sam. 17:33): I did not restrain myself, but leaped in for all, I received the enemy, I cut off his head, and like a certain rush of a torrent, I repelled the assaults of those barbarians, I stabilized the wavering republic: and through me, you indeed hold the kingdom and life, but all the others besides life, the city and homes, children and wives." And after that, again the trophy, and other wars which he had bravely and successfully waged, not inferior to these, he could have recalled. To this, that he had once and again, indeed many times, attempted to take him out of the midst, and had hurled a spear at his head: he does not remember the evils; likewise that after those deeds, when Saul should have given the rewards of the previous battle, he demanded a dowry, not gold, not silver, but slaughter and destruction: and not even that did David refuse. Nor only these, but he could have said many more and greater things: but he said none of these, nor was his mind inclined to reproach him with benefits, but only to persuade himself to be one of those who

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both loved and honored him, not who were plotting rebellion or treachery.

Therefore, besides all those things, he brought forth only what had happened on that day in his defense. He was so pure and free from all vain glory, nor did he look to anything else but to the will of the one God. Then he said: Let the Lord judge between me and you (Ibid. v. 13). He said this word not because he wished to punish Saul, or to take vengeance on him, but to instill fear in him from the mention of a future judgment: not only to provoke fear, but also to cleanse himself from the suspicion of crime. Indeed, he says, I have the chief proof from their own deeds: and if you do not believe, I call upon God Himself as a witness, who knows the secrets of every mind and can scrutinize consciences.

5. However, having spoken these things, he declared that he would by no means have dared to call upon that Judge, to whom no accusation can be brought, and to bring upon himself condemnation, unless he had the most certain knowledge that he was pure from all treachery. And that what we say is not conjecture, but that he, wishing both to purify himself and to recall him to sobriety, made mention of that judgment, those things which have already happened sufficiently show: nor, however, can those things which afterwards occurred fail to bear witness to this matter. For when Saul again fell into his hands, after seeking his life and wishing to kill him, and when he could have struck down the enemy with the whole army, he let him go unharmed and intact. Therefore, knowing that the king's disease was incurable, and that he would never set a hostile mind against him, he removed himself from his sight and lived among the barbarians, serving, deprived of honor, suffused with shame, preparing for himself the necessities of life through labor and misery. Yet this is not only what we marvel at, but also that after he had heard that the king had fallen in battle, he tore

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his clothes, and sprinkled himself with ashes, and mourned with such grief as one would mourn for a lost firstborn brother; immediately calling out his name along with the name of his son, composing also praises, and emitting cries as witnesses of bitter sorrow, he remained unfed until evening, cursing even the places that had received Saul's blood. "Mountains of Gilboa," he said, "let there be no dew or rain upon you: mountains of death, because there the tents of the mighty were lifted up" (2. Kings 1. 21). This is often done by fathers, that they even shun the house and look sadly upon the threshold through which they raised their son; this he also did, devoting those mountains which had received that slaughter. "I hate," he said, "even that place because of the dead lying there." Therefore, let you not be watered thereafter by heavenly rains, because you were once badly watered by the blood of my friends, and he repeatedly mentioned their names, speaking thus: "Saul and Jonathan, beloved and beautiful, in their life were not separated, nor in their death were they divided" (Ibid. v. 21). For since it was not permitted to embrace their absent bodies, he embraced their names, softening his sorrow in these ways as far as he could and mitigating the magnitude of calamity. For since it was thought by many to be an incurable evil that both fell on the same day, he seized this very thing as an argument for consolation. For what he says, "In their life they were not separated, nor in death are they divided," were words doing nothing else than that this may yield to the solace of sorrow. "Now," he said, "it cannot be said that the son mourns to be an orphan, nor that the father laments his bereavement: but what has not happened to anyone, has happened to them: namely, that they were both snatched from the living on the same day, neither surviving the other. For he thought that life would be unpleasant for him if one had been torn from the other. "Now you are moved, now you weep, and your minds are disturbed; have your eyes changed to the effusion of tears? Now let each one remember the enemy who has harmed him,

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still burning with pain in his heart, and let him both keep this one alive and mourn the one who has died, not indeed for ostentation, but from the heart, and with a true heart: and even if something burdensome must be endured, let him do all things then, let him suffer, expecting great rewards from God. Behold, here he has also attained the kingdom, and yet he did not stain his hands with blood, but having a pure right hand, thus he was crowned, thus he ascended to the throne, bearing a more magnificent praise with purple and diadem, namely that he had spared the enemy, that he had mourned the one who had been slain. Therefore, not only while alive, but even dead, he is celebrated in the memory of men. Wherefore, if you wish to attain everlasting glory here and to enjoy solid goods there, imitate the virtue of this just man, emulate the philosophy of this one, show through your very deeds this endurance of injuries, so that by enduring the same labors, you may attain the same goods: which may it be granted to us all to obtain, by the grace and kindness of our Lord Jesus Christ, to whom with the Father and the Holy Spirit be glory, dominion, honor, now and always, and unto ages of ages. Amen.

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That it is dangerous to approach spectacles, and that it makes perfect adulterers, and from this sadness and contention arise: then that all kinds of tolerance David surpassed in what he did towards Saul: finally, that bearing robbery with equanimity is no less a virtue than to bestow alms.

1. Indeed, I believe that many of those who had recently deserted and departed to the spectacles of iniquity are present today. I would wish, however, that those who are here might know openly, so that I may exclude them from the sacred vestibules, not that they may remain outside forever, but that corrected they may return again: since both fathers frequently expel delinquent sons from their houses and remove them from the table, not that they may always be excluded, but that, having been corrected, they may return better, with due praise and honor to their paternal lot. The same certainly do the shepherds, while they segregate the sheep afflicted with scab from the healthy, so that the wretched, having been healed, may safely return to the healthy, lest the sickly flock fill the whole with their disease. Therefore, we wished to know these; but although we cannot recognize them with the eyes of the body, the word will certainly recognize them, and their corrected conscience will easily persuade them to go out of their own accord, teaching that He alone is within who has a mind worthy of this exercise: just as on the contrary, he who lives corruptly as a partaker of this sacred congregation, even if he stands here in body, has been rejected, and is rather removed than those who have been excluded outside (a), to whom it is not yet permitted to be partakers of the sacred table. For indeed, those expelled according to divine laws and remaining outside are still in good hope: for if they wish to correct their sins, for which they have been expelled through the Church, they can return again with a pure conscience. But those who have defiled

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themselves, and having been admonished not to enter until they have cleansed the stain contracted from their crimes, then behave shamelessly, render the wound and ulcer of the soul more bitter and greater. For it is not so grave to sin, as to behave shamelessly after sin, nor to disobey the priests commanding such things. And what, they say, have these committed that is so great a crime, that they should be excluded from these sacred thresholds? Rather, what sin is graver than that of those who have contaminated themselves with adultery, shamelessly and like rabid dogs, rush to this sacred table? But if you wish to know the measure of adultery, I will not refer to my words, but to His who will judge concerning the whole life of man: For whoever looks at a woman to lust after her has already committed adultery with her in his heart (Matthew 5:28). But if a woman, perhaps, in the marketplace, and carelessly dressed, often captures the gaze of one looking at her with curiosity; those who do not simply, nor by chance, but with intent, and with such intent that they also despise the Church, and for this reason proceed there, and spend the whole day there with their eyes fixed on the faces of those fallen women, with what face can they say that they did not see them to lust after? Where words also come, broken and lascivious, where the temptations of a harlot, where the voice composed vehemently for pleasure, where the eyes painted with stibium, where the cheeks dyed with colors, where the dress is more carefully arranged, where the whole body is full of artifice, and many other lures are prepared to deceive and ensnare the onlookers; where the sloth of the spectators, and much confusion, this very place inviting to lust, then from those performances that have preceded, then from those that have followed? There come temptations through pipes and flutes, and other such modulations, enticing to fraud, softening the strength of the mind, and preparing the souls of those sitting there for the snares and delights of harlots, making it easier for them to be captured. Indeed, if here, where there are psalms, where prayers, where

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the narration of divine words, where the fear of God, and much piety, frequently, like a cunning thief, lust creeps in secretly: how can those who sit in the theater, who hear and see nothing healthy, but many things flow with filth, many wickedness, who suffer siege on all sides, through the ears, through the eyes, overcome evil lust? Again, if they cannot, how can they ever be absolved from the crime of adultery? Then those who are not free from the crime of adultery, how can they approach these sacred thresholds without repentance, and be partakers of this illustrious assembly?

2. Therefore, I indeed urge and beseech you, that first through confession and penance and all other remedies, you cleanse yourselves from the sin contracted from theatrical spectacles, and thus listen to divine sermons. For it is not a small matter that we are led astray; this can be clearly seen from examples. For if a servant were to place a filthy and lice-infested tunic upon a chest where the master's precious and golden garments are stored, tell me, would you bear that insult with a calm spirit? But what if someone were to pour filth and excrement into a golden vessel, in which perfumes are usually kept, would you not inflict punishments on the one who committed such a crime? Are we then to be so careful about chests and vessels, garments and perfumes, and yet think our soul is worth less than all these, and where the Spirit has been infused, we unleash diabolical pomp? There we introduce the fables of Satan, there the songs full of the filth of harlotry? Tell me, how will God bear these things? Yet the difference between perfume and excrement, between noble and servile garments, is not as great as the difference between the grace of the Spirit and this perverse action. Do not be deceived, O man, while with what eyes you gaze upon the bed that is in the orchestra, where the detestable fables of adultery are performed, do you also look upon the sacred table, where the tremendous mysteries are enacted? While with the same ears

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you hear the obscene harlot speaking, and the prophet introducing the apostle and the secrets of Scripture? While with the same heart you take in deadly poisons, and this holy and terrible victim? Are these not the subversion of life, the corruption of marriages, wars and fights in homes? For when you return home from those spectacles, more dissolute and softer and more lascivious, having become an enemy of all modesty, the sight of your wife will be less pleasant, whatever she may be. For having been inflamed by that lust, which you have drawn in from the theaters, and captivated by that foreign spectacle, which has driven you mad, you despise your chaste and modest wife, your companion for all of life, you insult her, and with countless reproaches you act, not because you have anything to blame in her, but because you are ashamed to confess the disease, ashamed to show the wound, by which you returned home wounded from the spectacles, seeking other excuses, looking for occasions of unjust enmity, despising all that is at home, and gazing with desire at that wicked and impure lust, from which you received the wound, while you carry the sound of the voice lingering in your mind, as well as the sight, the movements, and all those images of harlotry, you regard nothing of what is at home with pleasure. And what shall I say about your wife or family, when you will even be less willing to see the church afterwards, and with weariness will listen to the discourse on chastity and modesty? For what is said to you is no longer for teaching, but for accusation, and will gradually lead you into despair: finally, you will even break yourself from the discipline applied for the public good. Therefore, I ask you all, that you yourselves avoid the wicked dwelling in spectacles, and that you withdraw others who have been led away by these. For whatever is done there is not amusement; but destruction, but punishment, but torment. What good is that temporary pleasure, when from it perpetual pain arises, and while being stimulated by lust both night and day, you are a burden and hated by all? Therefore,

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shake yourself off, considering what you become upon returning from the church, again what you are from the spectacles, and compare these days with those: if you do this, there will be no need for our discourse. For it will be sufficient to have compared this day with that one, to show both how great the benefit is from here, and how great the harm is from there. I thought it fitting to say these things now to your charity, nor will I ever cease to speak. Thus indeed we will admonish those who are afflicted by this disease, and we will strengthen those who are healthy: for this prayer will be useful for both: for some indeed to desist, for others not to fall. Moreover, since it is necessary for the rebuke to be moderate, we will put an end to this admonition, and we will address what remains from the previous topic, returning to David. For it is customary for painters, whenever they wish to finish a likeness drawn from life, to sit with those whom they are painting for one, two, or three days, so that through constant contemplation they may express the likeness accurately and without error. Therefore, since it is proposed to us not to depict the image of a bodily form, but the beauty of the soul, and the spiritual adornment, we wish David himself to be present to you, so that all, looking upon him, may refer to their minds the expressed beauty of justice, sweetness, magnanimity, and in sum, all his virtue. Indeed, if bodily images bring some comfort to those who gaze upon them, much more will the images of the mind do the same. And those indeed cannot be gazed upon anywhere, but you must stand in the same place: however, nothing prevents you from carrying this with you wherever you wish. For after you have placed it in the innermost parts of your mind, wherever you may be, you will be able to contemplate it often, and derive much benefit from it. And just as those who labor with their eyes, if they frequently gaze upon sponges and cloths of a blue color, derive some relief from that color, so too, if you have the image of David before your eyes, and you fix your eyes upon it continually, even if a thousand times the anger of the

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mind disturbs your eye, looking at this example of virtue, you will attain perfect health and pure philosophy of the soul.

3. No enemy is worse than Saul. - Therefore, let no one say to me: I have a wicked, corrupt, incorrigible enemy. Whatever you may say, yet Saul is not worse, who once and again, indeed many times, was spared by David, although he had laid traps for him in a thousand ways; nevertheless, for so many benefits received, he persisted in his wickedness. What then do you have to accuse the enemy? What part of the land did he take away, what injury did he do in the fields, what boundaries of the house did he transgress, what did he seize of your possessions, what violence did he inflict, what did he occupy beyond right, what did he reduce to poverty? But he has not yet taken life, which Saul attempted: and if he even tried to take life, perhaps he dared it once, not once, twice or thrice, or many times, as Saul did: and if he attempted this even once, twice, thrice, or many times, yet not so many affections from you for benefits, yet not when he had once and again fallen into your hands, and was spared: and if this also happened, thus David again overcomes. For they are not equal under the old law, and now after the grace of the Gospel to forgive such things freely. David had not heard the parable of the ten thousand talents and the hundred denarii; he had not heard the prayer saying, Forgive men their debts, as your heavenly Father (Mark 11:25): he had not seen Christ crucified, nor the precious blood poured out, nor had he heard countless sermons about this philosophy; he had not been a partaker of such a sacrifice, nor of the blood of the Lord, but raised under imperfect laws, nor demanding anything like this, yet he reached the height of evangelical philosophy. But you, frequently angry, keep the memory of injuries: yet he, when fearing for the future, knowing for certain that if he spared the enemy, he would be exiled from the city and would live a wretched life, nevertheless did not cease to care for

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him, but did everything, nurturing such an enemy against himself. Who can recall greater patience than this? Moreover, so that you may learn not only from the past, but also from what is now happening, that you can return to favor with any man bearing a hostile spirit, what is fiercer than a lion? And yet men make this fierce and savage creature gentle, overcoming nature by art: and any wild beast becomes milder than all the most ferocious and proud, so much so that it walks through the marketplace, frightening no one. What excuse then shall we have, what pardon shall we obtain, if we can tame wild beasts, and deny that men could ever be placated and made favorable towards us? Indeed, it is beyond nature for a beast to be tame, but for a man it is beyond nature to be savage. Therefore, when we conquer nature in them, with what face shall we excuse ourselves, if we claim that the disposition of the mind in a man cannot be corrected? But if you still contend, I would say this: although a man is afflicted with an incurable disease, the more labor there is, the greater will be your reward; if you sit by, caring for one suffering from an incurable disease.

Let us therefore consider this one thing, not that we may suffer any evil from our enemies, but that we may not do any evil to them: thus we shall suffer no evil, even if we endure countless evils: just as David, when he is cast out, when he is driven into exile, when he is pursued to the point of death by ambushes, suffered nothing bitter: rather, he became more illustrious and honorable in the eyes of his enemy, and more lovable than all others, and this not only to men, but even to God Himself. For what harm did that holy man suffer when he endured so much from Saul? Is he not still sung of today as illustrious on earth, more illustrious in heaven? Are not unspeakable goods reserved for him and the kingdom of heaven? Again, what advantage did that unfortunate and miserable man gain, having plotted so many ambushes? Was he not cast out of the kingdom? Did he not perish a

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wretched death along with his son, and is he not reviled by all (1. Reg. ult.), and what is more grievous than this, does he not pay eternal punishments? Finally, what is it that you accuse, why do you not wish to return to favor with him? Did he take away your money? But if you bravely endure the robbery, you will receive as much reward as if you had restored it into the hands of the poor. For indeed, both he who gives to the needy and he who has usurped what is another's, neither plots ambushes, nor prays ill, both do this for the sake of God. Therefore, since the cause of the expenditure is the same, it is evident that it will be one and the same crown. But was he ambushed in life, and did he attempt to kill? This matter will be imputed to you as martyrdom, if you are counted among those who plot ambushes, and in such great enmity, while you continually pray for him, beseeching God that He may be merciful to him. 4. Therefore, let us not consider that God forbade Saul to kill David: but consider that he was redeemed from the ambushes of Saul by a triple or quadruple crown of martyrdom. For he who served his enemy for the sake of God, he who once, twice, indeed frequently hurled a spear at his head, when he had the power to kill, nevertheless spared him, knowing afterwards that he would again be attacked by him: it is evident that he was killed a thousand times in his mind; and having been killed a thousand times for the sake of God, he received many crowns of martyrdom: just as Paul says, I die daily for the sake of God (Rom. 8. 26), so too did he suffer for the sake of God. For when he could have removed the enemy who was lying in wait for him, for the sake of God he did not wish to, and preferred to be in danger daily than to be freed from so many deaths by a single blow. If it is not right to avenge oneself on the one who lies in wait for him even to the peril of his own life, much less is it permitted to avenge oneself on one who has wronged him in a common manner.

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It seems intolerable to most people to be affected by insults from enemies or to be brought into suspicion, more so than by all deaths. Come then, let us weigh this matter. Has someone cursed you, called you an adulterer and a deceiver? If he speaks truly, correct yourself; if falsely, mock him; if you are conscious of the things that are being said against you, repent; if not, disregard it: rather, not only do not mock and neglect, but also rejoice and exult according to the Lord's word, who commands us to do so. For He says, when they revile you and say all evil against you falsely, rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven (Matt. 5:11-12). And again, Rejoice and be glad when they cast out your name as evil, falsely (Luke 6:22-25). Moreover, if the reviler has spoken some truth, you should bear those words modestly, not returning insult or reproach, but rather lamenting your sins with love; you will not receive a lesser reward than the first: and I will endeavor to prove this to you from the Scriptures, so that you may understand that friends bring us utility not only when they praise and speak kindly, but that enemies bring us utility by reproaching us, even if they have spoken the truth, in such a way that we may wish to use their accusations for what is necessary. For friends often flatter for favor; on the contrary, enemies bring our sins to light. Since when we do not see our own sins because of the love ingrained in us, they, because of their hatred, see them better than we do, and by reproaching us, they drive us to the necessity of correction: so that their enmity may yield us the greatest benefit, not only because we understand our errors when admonished by them, but also because we lay them aside. For if an enemy reproaches you with a sin of which you are conscious, you should not return insult to him in turn, but with bitter groaning implore God, and immediately you have laid aside all blame. I ask what could be more delightful than this? What could be easier for the abolition of sins? But lest we seem to be roused by human words, let us bring forth testimony from divine Scriptures on this matter, so that you may have

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no further doubt. There were a Pharisee and a publican, of whom one had indeed progressed to the height of malice, the other exercised the height of righteousness, as one who distributed his resources and fasted often, pure from plunder: on the contrary, the other had consumed his life in plunder and violence. Both went up to the temple to pray. The former standing prayed thus: I thank you, Lord, that I am not like other men, extortioners, unjust, nor even like this publican (Luke 18:11-12). But the publican standing afar off would not even lift his eyes to heaven, nor did he return insult in turn, nor did he utter those common words: Do you dare to mention my life and to reproach my deeds? Am I not better than you? I will recount your sins, and may you never dare to enter these sacred courts. No, I say, the publican spoke none of those cold words, with which we daily sprinkle each other with mutual insults; but, loving, he sighed and struck his breast, saying only this, God, be merciful to me, a sinner (Ib. v. 13), and he went down justified.

Do you see the swiftness? He received disgrace, and he washed away disgrace; he recognized sins, and he laid down sins: and the accusation of crimes became for him the remission of crimes, and the ignorant enemy became beneficent. How many labors were there for the publican to undergo, fasting, sleeping on the ground, staying awake, sharing his goods with the needy, sitting for a long time in sackcloth and ashes, so that he could lay down such great sins? But now, when he has done nothing of the sort, with a simple word he laid down all iniquity: and the disgraceful insults of the Pharisees, who seemed to afflict him with reproach, gave him the crown of righteousness, and that without sweat, without labors, and without a long delay. Do you see us, even if someone truly preaches to us, of whom we ourselves are aware, that we do not in turn subject the one preaching these things to curses, but rather, groaning in love, we implore God for our offenses,

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that he might be able to lay down all sins? In this way, he was justified here: for since the Pharisee did not retaliate with insults, but groaned for his own sins, he went down justified rather than the other.

5. Do you see how much benefit the reproach of enemies brings, if only we can endure it with a philosophical mind? But if both those who lie and those who speak the truth are beneficial to us, why do we grieve? For what reason are we inflamed? Unless you harm yourself, O man, neither friend nor enemy, not even the devil himself can harm you. Indeed, since those who insult us, who slander us, who plot against our very lives, bring us benefit, and others weave for us the crown of martyrdom, as we have shown, while others again, by reproaching us for our sins, make us just, as happened with the publican, why are we enraged and inflamed against them? Therefore, let us not say: "He has provoked me terribly, he has compelled me to speak dishonorable words: we are the cause of such things everywhere." For if we wish to be philosophical, not even the demon can incite us to anger: this is evident both from many lofty examples and from this very history of David, which it would be worthwhile to bring forth today, if we first remind you of your love, where we recently concluded our sermon. Where then did we conclude it? In the excuse of David. Therefore, it is necessary that today we refer to the words of Saul, so that we may see what he responded to the most just excuse of David. For we shall perceive David's virtue not only from the words that David spoke but also from Saul's speech: for if Saul responded somewhat calmly and gently, we shall attribute this to David, who changed the man, who educated him, and composed his mind to sobriety. What then does Saul say? After he had heard David speaking, "Behold, the corner of your cloak is in my hand" (1 Kings 24:13), and all that he brought forth in excuse: "Is this your voice, my son David?" (Ibid. v. 17)? How great a change has suddenly occurred!

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He who had never even tolerated calling him by a simple name, having the very appellation hateful, now adopts him into kinship, calling him son. What then is more fortunate than David, who made a father out of a murderer, a sheep out of a wolf, who filled the furnace of wrath with much dew, who turned the storm into tranquility, and who extinguished all the swelling of the mind's boiling anger? Indeed, the words of David entered the mind of that enraged man, completing this entire transformation, which you can perceive from Saul's words. For he did not say, "These are your speeches, my son David?" but, "Is this your voice, my son David?" Thus he immediately became inflamed by the very voice. And just as a father, upon hearing the voice of his returning son after a long interval, is stirred not only at the sight of him but also at the very voice: so also Saul, as soon as the words of David entered his mind, cast aside enmity, and now recognized the holy one, having laid aside his affection, he received affection. For indeed, having set aside anger, he received tranquility and compassion. And just as as long as night is present, we often do not even recognize a present friend, but as soon as day has arisen, we even recognize him from afar: so too does enmity tend to happen. As long as we harbor a malevolent spirit among us, the voice sounds differently to us, and we behold the very face with a corrupted mind: but when we have laid aside anger, the voice which was previously hateful and hostile seems pleasant and most delightful to us, and the very appearance which was previously hostile and unpleasant then becomes lovable and delightful.

6. When anger is released, we clearly discern what, in fervent anger, did not appear to us. The voice of David is most powerful. - The same happens in a storm. The gathering of clouds does not allow us to see the beauty of the sky; but although we have the sharpest eyes, we cannot reach that heavenly delight. But when the warmth of the rays, breaking through and dispersing the clouds, reveals the sun, it again

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shows the beauty of the sky. The same happens in us when we are fervent with anger; while strife stands before our eyes and ears like a dense cloud, it causes voices and appearances to seem different from what they are. But as soon as someone has philosophized and put aside hatred, and has torn away the cloud of sorrow, then at last with an incorrupt mind he can act, so as to extinguish all that bitterness, which is not obscured by all those who have ever deserved a clear name in the doctrine of philosophy?

Nothing is more powerful than humanity. It is in our power to calm anger. Therefore, if ever an enemy falls into your hands, do not consider how you might take revenge on him, or send him away covered with countless insults, but rather how you might heal him, how you might bring him back to sobriety: nor should you cease to do and say all these things until your gentleness overcomes his ferocity. For nothing is more powerful than humanity. This very thing was declared by someone, saying: A soft word will break bones (Prov. 25. 15). But what is harder than bone? And yet if someone is as hard and rigid as a rock, he can easily be overcome by one who treats him gently. Moreover, a gentle answer turns away wrath (Prov. 15. 1). Hence it is clear that whether an enemy is provoked or reconciled is more in your power than in his. For it is not in those who are stirred up with anger, but it is in us, whether their anger is extinguished or their fire is kindled. And this too, the one who said the earlier things declared with a simple example. For just as, he says, if you blow on a small fire, you stir up a blaze: on the contrary, if you spit on it, you extinguish it, and both are in your hands (for both, he says, come forth from your mouth [Eccli. 28. 14]): so also in enmity towards your neighbor, if you introduce inflated and reckless words, you stir up his fire, you kindle coals: but if you bring forth gentle and moderate words, before he bursts into flames, you will have extinguished all his anger. Therefore

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do not say: I have suffered this, or I have heard this, when all these things are in your power. For in this way, anger, like a spark, is either to be extinguished or kindled, and fury is either to be stirred up or calmed, it is in you. When you see an enemy, or if many things come to mind that you have heard or suffered from him, make sure to forget all these things; and even if you remember, make sure to strike them against the devil. Indeed, gather if ever he has spoken or done anything humanely. If you dwell on these memories, you will quickly dissolve enmity. But if your mind is inclined to accuse him, and to argue with him: first cast aside the movement of your spirit, extinguish your anger, and then argue with him, then rebuke him, and you will be able to conquer easily. For when stirred up with anger, we can say or hear nothing healthy: but freed from disturbance, neither will we ever emit a harsher word, nor will we hear others speaking harshly in the same way. For neither does the very nature of what is said, nor does the mind occupied with hatred, usually provoke us. For it often happens that when the same insults are hurled at us by friends joking or playing, or by little children, we feel not only no annoyance, nor are we provoked, but we even laugh and are delighted, because we do not hear those things with a corrupted affection of the mind, nor with a mind preoccupied with anger. Likewise with enemies, if you extinguish anger, if you cast out hatred, nothing of the words that are said can offend you.

8. More deserving of tears is he who does injury. But what do I say about words? Not even deeds have offended, just as nothing of these has offended the blessed one; but when he saw the enemy armed against his safety, leaving nothing unattempted for his sake, he was not only not exasperated, but rather grieved more for his evils: the more vehemently that one lay in wait, the more intensely he mourned for him. For he knew, I say, he certainly knew, that it is not he who suffers

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injury, but he who does it, who is worthy of tears and lamentations, as one who harms himself. Therefore, he made long use of excuses before him, nor did he cease until he had moved the enemy to excuse himself with tears and lamentations. For after he wept and let out a voice of lamentation, after he cried out clearly, listen to what he says. "You are more just than I, for you have repaid me good, but I have truly repaid you evil" (1. Reg. 24. 18). You see how he condemns his own malice, and proclaims the virtue of the just, purging him without any coercion? The same you do quickly. When the enemy has offended in your hands, do not accuse him, but purge yourself, so that you may compel him to his own condemnation. For if we accuse, he is exasperated: but if we excuse, he, revering our humanity, will soon condemn himself. In this way, both reproof is made without suspicion, and he sheds all malice. This also happens here: when he who was affected by the injury is silent, he who has done much accuses himself with great intensity. For he did not simply say, "You have done good to me," but, "You have repaid me good": that is, "For the ambushes, for the slaughter, for those countless evils, you have repaid me great benefits." But I have not even become better for your benefits, but after those good deeds of yours, I have persisted in malice: you, however, have not been changed either, but you have steadfastly maintained your custom, pursuing us again with benefits. In all these individual words, how many crowns did David appear worthy of? For although the mouth of Saul sounded these things, yet the wisdom and skill of David had sown them in his mind. "You have announced to me today what good you have done to me, since the Lord has delivered me today into your hands, and you have not killed me" (1. Reg. 24. 19). Behold again he bore witness to his other virtue, namely, that the benefactor did not remain silent, nor did he dissimulate, but coming forward he narrated; not indeed for ostentation, but wishing to teach him through the very deeds, that he was among those who wished well to the king and

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looked out for his interests, not among those who laid traps. For then it is right to commemorate one's own benefits when a notable utility is hoped for from this. For whenever someone boasts and proclaims his benefits to another without any given occasion, he is no better than one reproaching; however, whenever he does this to turn around the ill-affected and the wrong opinion held about him, he is both a guardian and a benefactor: which indeed David did, not seeking glory from Saul, but striving to uproot the anger rooted in him. And for this reason, Saul praised him, because he was both a benefactor and had commemorated the merits.

Then indeed certain rewards remain for us with God, when they are denied by men. - Then, when Saul, wishing to show gratitude, could find no equal, he made God Himself his debtor, speaking thus: If someone finds his enemy in distress and lets him go on a good way, the Lord will repay him good, as you have done to me today (1. Reg. 24. 20). For what could Saul return worthy of his merits, even if he had given him the kingdom with all its cities? For David had not only given him cities and the kingdom, but even his very life: yet he had no other life to repay; and thus he refers him to God, and honors him with the rewards to be given by Him: and praising him, and instructing all, he shows that greater rewards are laid up for us with God, when for countless benefits conferred upon an enemy we receive various things in return. After this he says: Behold, I acknowledge that you will surely reign, and that the kingdom of Israel will be established in your hand, and now swear to me by the Lord that you will not abolish my seed after me, nor extinguish my name from the house of my father (Ibid. v. 21. 22). But I ask you, whence do you know this? The armies are with you, the money is with you, the arms, the cities, the horses, the soldiers, in short, all the power of royal equipment: here I am deserted and naked, having neither city, nor house, nor family. Whence then, I

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pray, do you speak these things? Certainly from the very character of David. For he would not have overcome me, naked and unarmed and deserted, with such great power surrounding him, unless he had God as his helper; moreover, he who has God favoring him is more powerful than all. Do you see to what great philosophy Saul has been led after the ambush? Do you see how it could happen that an enemy casts off all malice and, unchanged, receives himself to better things?

9. Therefore, let us not despair of our salvation. For even if we have been led to the very depths of wickedness, it is possible for us to recall ourselves from there and to cast off all wickedness.

What does he say next? Swear to me by God that you will not abolish my seed after me, nor will you obliterate my name from my father's house. The king asks for a private matter: he who is crowned with a diadem acts as a suppliant, beseeching for his sons as an exile. And this itself proves the virtue of David, that the enemy dared to ask this from the enemy. For the oath he demands does not arise from distrust of David's character, but from considering how many evils he would have inflicted upon him. Swear to me that you will not abolish my seed after me. He leaves the enemy as a guardian for his sons, and he places his own offspring in the hands of that one, while with these words, grasping the hands of the sons and of David, he introduces God as a witness. What then does David do? Does he even lightly resort to dissimulation and irony in this? Not at all: but he immediately agrees and grants what was requested; and after Saul's death, not only did he not kill his descendants, but he also did more than he had promised. For he brought his son, who was lame and weak in his legs (2 Sam. 9), into his own house, and made him a participant at his table, honoring him greatly, and he did not feel ashamed, nor did he hide it, nor did he think that the royal table would be dishonored by the lameness of the boy, but rather that it would be adorned and made more splendid. For

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as many as reclined with him, they departed having gained a great teaching of philosophy. For when they saw the son of Saul, he who had perpetrated such great evils against David, to be held in such dishonor by him, even if they had been fiercer than all wild beasts, they returned to favor with all their enemies, filled with shame and blush. Although if he had commanded that he be given something from elsewhere, and had arranged a certain measure of sustenance, it would have been very great: but to receive him at his own table is an extraordinary act of philosophy. You surely know that it is not easy to love the sons of enemies. What did I say, to love? Not to hate, not to pursue, is great. Therefore many, after their enemies have died, have poured out their anger upon their children, which they had against them. But this noble and magnanimous man, not only observed the living enemy, but also, after he was dead, showed the goodwill he had towards him to his sons. What table could be more sacred than that which was surrounded by the sons of the enemy, I say, who had attempted to kill the enemy? What could be more spiritual than that banquet, in which so many blessings abounded? It was more like a gathering of angels than of a man calling. For indeed to embrace and love the sons of enemies, and to do so for the son of him who had so often attempted to take him out of life, is to bring that chorus upon him. Do this too, dear one, and nurturing the sons of both the living and the dead: indeed for the living, in this way you may win their parents to you; but for the dead, caring for their sons, so that from God you may receive much favor and be adorned with many crowns, and that you may obtain countless prayers and vows from all, not only from those who have been helped by your benefits, but also from those who have seen. On that day, he will stand for you, and great will be your patrons in the time of judgment, enemies helped by your benefit: you will expiate many sins, and you will demand your reward. Even if you have committed countless sins, if you bring forth that prayer which says: Forgive your enemies, and

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your Father will forgive you your sins (Matt. 6:14): with great confidence you will obtain the remission of all that has been committed, and in the meantime you will live with good hope, having all affectionately disposed towards you. When they see you loving enemies and the sons of enemies in this way, what will happen, that your friends and those eager for you will not desire to be your friends and to do all things for your sake? Moreover, when you have so much favor with God, when you have all good things praying for you, what trouble will you feel, or who will live a happier life than you? We do not only praise these things in this life, but also we keep them upon leaving here, and walking about for the sake of examining enemies, we reconcile them to ourselves, and make sincere friends out of enemies. But if an excuse is needed, and forgiveness must be sought from them, let us not refuse, even if we have been wronged ourselves. In this way, our reward will be more abundant, in this way greater confidence, in this way we shall undoubtedly obtain the kingdom of heaven, by the grace and goodness of our Lord Jesus Christ, with whom to the Father together and the Holy Spirit be glory, dominion, honor now and always, and for ages of ages. Amen.